

Point of view / perspective - Study Guide

Identify whose perspective is presented, what that perspective emphasizes, and how multiple viewpoints differ.

Learning goal

Distinguish narrator, author, speaker, and quoted viewpoints and analyze how perspective shapes emphasis, interpretation, or information.

What this skill really means

Perspective is more than identifying first person or third person. It includes what a person notices, values, knows, assumes, or emphasizes.

Informational texts can contain several perspectives: the author may report the views of residents, officials, researchers, and critics without fully adopting any one of them.

Literary point of view affects what readers know. A first-person narrator may reveal thoughts directly but may also have limited knowledge of other characters.

Question	What to examine	Common evidence
Who is speaking or narrating?	pronouns and narration	I/we vs he/she/they
What does this person value?	evaluative language and selected details	benefit, concern, praise, criticism
Whose view is quoted?	attribution	according to, said, argued, recalled
Does the author adopt that view?	framing around the quote	supporting evidence, contrast, neutral reporting

Question	What to examine	Common evidence
What can the narrator know?	access to thoughts/events	internal thoughts vs observed behavior

How exam-style questions ask it

- How does the narrator's point of view affect what the reader learns?
- Which statement best describes the author's perspective?
- How do the two speakers differ in their views of the proposal?
- Why does the author include the resident's perspective?

A reliable method

1. Identify the source of each statement: narrator, author, quoted speaker, or another character.
2. Mark words that show approval, concern, doubt, certainty, or emphasis.
3. Separate facts reported by the text from opinions held by a person in the text.
4. Compare what each perspective focuses on or values.
5. Choose the answer supported by what the perspective actually says or notices, not by what you personally agree with.

Tips and shortcuts

- A quotation does not automatically represent the author's own opinion.
- First-person narration gives direct access to one person's thoughts, not perfect knowledge of everyone else.
- When comparing viewpoints, use the same issue as the basis of comparison.

Worked examples

Example 1

A report states that the city plans a protected bus lane. A shop owner says the lane may reduce parking, while a transit rider says it will make the commute safer. The report then presents traffic data without endorsing either quotation.

1. How does the author handle the two perspectives?

- A. The author clearly adopts the shop owner's view.
- B. The author presents competing concerns before adding neutral evidence.
- C. The author proves both speakers are wrong.
- D. The author avoids mentioning any disagreement.

Answer: B

The author attributes each view to a different speaker and then provides data rather than claiming either quotation as the author's own position.

Example 2

I watched Mira close the workshop door and place the key in her pocket. She smiled, but I could not tell whether she was relieved or disappointed.

2. What limitation does the first-person point of view create?

- A. The narrator cannot report Mira's action.
- B. The narrator cannot know Mira's private feeling with certainty.
- C. The narrator cannot describe the setting.
- D. The narrator knows every character's thoughts.

Answer: B

The narrator observes Mira's behavior but explicitly cannot know what she feels.

Common traps

- Treating a quoted person's opinion as the author's view.

- Confusing point of view with tone.
- Assuming a first-person narrator is always reliable or fully informed.
- Choosing a difference that concerns different issues rather than the same issue.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, name the exact relationship between the target wording and the larger text. Point to evidence for that relationship, not just a familiar label.

Quick check

1. Why should you not treat every quotation as the author's own opinion?
2. What can a first-person narrator know directly that an outside observer may not?
3. When comparing two viewpoints, what should stay constant?

Quick check guidance

Explain the relationship in plain language before using a technical label. If your explanation works only as a summary, ask what job, purpose, perspective, or effect is still missing.